10 SWAPS, AND WHAT TO SAY WHEN TWO URGENT ASKS COLLIDE

What to Say When Your Manager Sends Something Urgent

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1 When it lands, say yes and name the trade

Agree to the ask and say what moves because of it, in the same message.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "Got it, I'll jump on it."
> Instead say: "I'll jump on it. The roadmap draft moves to Thursday."
>
> Don't say: "No problem, I'll make it work."
> Instead say: "Yes. To fit it in, the vendor review slides a day."

Put the trade in the same message as the yes.

2 When you'd drop everything, let them choose

Hand the priority call back to the person who made it urgent.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "I'll drop what I'm doing."
> Instead say: "I'm on the pricing doc and the launch plan. Which one waits?"
>
> Don't say: "I'll stay late and get it done."
> Instead say: "I can finish this tonight if the launch plan moves to Monday. Your call."

Name the two things it competes with so the choice is easy.

3 When they say ASAP, get a time

Turn ASAP into a time you can hit.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "Sure, ASAP."
> Instead say: "By 3 today or end of day?"
>
> Don't say: "I'll get to it as soon as I can."
> Instead say: "You'll have it by noon tomorrow. Does that work?"

If they won't pick a time, pick one yourself and say it back.

4 When you're at capacity, show the list

Show what's already on your plate instead of saying you're busy.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "I'm slammed, but okay."
> Instead say: "Yes. Here's what moves to Monday."
> Don't say: "I've got a lot going on this week."
> Instead say: "This week I have the launch, the QBR deck and two interviews. Which one slides?"

Keep a short list of what you're carrying so you can paste it in.

5 When you doubt it's urgent, ask for the real deadline

Ask what happens later instead of asking if it's urgent.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Is this really urgent?"
> Instead say: "What happens if this lands Friday?"
> Don't say: "Does this have to be today?"
> Instead say: "Who's waiting on this, and when do they need it?"

If the real deadline is later, you just got your week back.

6 When two urgent asks collide, put them side by side

Send both asks to the people who made them, in one message, with the trade.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Sorry, I've got two fires going. I'll get to yours when I can."
> Instead say: "I have two urgent asks: the pricing fix for Sam and the exec summary for you. I can do one by 3 and the other by noon tomorrow. Which goes first?"

Let the people who made it urgent pick the order. Your job is to make the trade visible.

Check every urgent yes before you send it

Run this before you answer the next urgent ask:

- [ ] Did you say what moves when you said yes?
- [ ] Did the person who made it urgent pick what slips?
- [ ] Did ASAP turn into a time?
- [ ] Did you show the list instead of saying busy?
- [ ] Did you ask what happens if it lands later?